STATUS REPORT

DR Congo — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-08-25 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

DR Congo's digital economy sector policy passed government validation on 4 August 2026, a third gate after expert validation on 21-22 July and the AI strategy's technical validation on 23-27 July. The PSEN 2026-2030 is framed as the reference instrument for planning, programming, budgeting, coordination and monitoring of public interventions in the sector, and as validated it runs on six axes to 2030: infrastructure, digital transformation of the administration, digital economy, innovation and start-ups, cybersecurity, and data governance.

What the experts approved, they approved conditionally. The final text must still stabilise the results chain and programme nomenclature, complete the baseline data, indicators and annual targets, finish the costing against the medium-term expenditure framework, and clarify institutional responsibilities — a validated policy that is not yet a budgetable one. Ministries were then instructed on 4 August 2026 to convert it into sectoral programmes carrying indicators and budget allocations.

Delivery ownership sits with the digital economy ministry, which presented a digital maturity diagnostic across ten dimensions at a workshop on 29-30 July 2026 and set out to order and make executable the instruments the state already holds — the digital economy and data governance strategies, the AI strategy, RDC-PASS, the sovereign cloud, ANCE and the cybersecurity agency — rather than write another parallel strategy. The technical work was done by the regulator: ARPTC collected the data from public institutions, mobilised focal points and supervised the experts, putting the sector regulator at the pen drafting policy for the ministry that supervises it. Sectoral commitments continue alongside: an ICT-for-education policy adopted on 12 June 2026 aims explicitly at making scattered education technology initiatives interoperable.

Money, not intent, is the stated constraint: on the flagship digital transformation programme the minister named budget constraints, insufficient national resources and a low disbursement rate on external financing, asking for exceptional domestic financing to compensate (August 2026). The administrative base is weak and weakening: budgetary and financial management fell 18.0 points over 2014-2023 to 41.7 out of 100, 43rd of 54 African states, and the country sits below the continental average on all 16 governance sub-categories.

Legislation and regulation

Three years after the framework law that was meant to cover it, national identification still has no statute of its own: two deputies tabled a bill in the National Assembly in June 2026 that would establish a single legal framework for identification and mandate interoperability across the civil registry, migration and health databases, and it is a proposal rather than law.

The instrument in force is the Digital Code of 13 March 2023, which covers digital identity, electronic authentication, e-government, cybersecurity, e-commerce and data protection and creates the electronic certification authority ANCE, the digital market regulator ARN and the national cybersecurity agency ANC; several of its implementing decrees remain outstanding, and the data protection authority it provides for has not been established. Before it, the Telecommunications and ICT Law N. 20/017 of 25 November 2020 carried the country's first data protection provisions. The universal service fund created by law in November 2020 then went more than five years without operational funding.

Most of what has been built since has been built by decree rather than by statute: the General Population File in March 2022, the court case-management system SIGAJ in March 2025, the Registre Social Unique in December 2025. The exception is land: Land Law n. 25/62 of December 2025, the first substantive revision since 1973, mandates full digitisation of the cadastre, with implementation across the 26 provinces at an early stage. The hole that matters most is horizontal — no comprehensive cross-government data-sharing law exists, so each register is authorised on its own terms.

Enforcement is being assembled after the fact: the subcontracting regulator ARSP and the telecoms regulator ARPTC agreed on 22 July 2026 to harmonise their reading of the texts, run joint inspection teams and enforce local-content rules on large operators.

Data protection

The supervisory body the law requires does not exist: the data protection authority mandated by Article 262 of the Digital Code has not been established by decree, and a ministerial decree of 17 August 2024 transferred its functions on an interim basis to the telecommunications regulator ARPTIC. That absence runs alongside a twenty-year public-private partnership signed on 25 June 2025 making a single foreign company the exclusive electronic know-your-customer provider for the country's mobile subscribers, whose contract terms are undisclosed and for which no independent security review or privacy impact assessment has been published.

On paper the regime is substantial. Book III of the Digital Code covers biometric identifiers such as fingerprints, facial images and iris scans, data subject rights, controller obligations, breach notification and penalties, and applies across sectors including mobile and electronic payment providers, credit institutions and microfinance institutions. Notification of a breach to the authority is a legal mandate rather than a discretionary practice. The Code also requires explicit prior consent for most transfers, imposes an authorisation regime for sensitive data including national identification numbers and biometrics, and permits transfer abroad only to jurisdictions offering equal or better protection — with the implementing decrees not issued, so these rules are not enforceable in practice.

Redress is thin in the same way. There is no identity-specific judicial remedy: oversight runs through the ordinary courts, and the Code's rights of access and rectification are exercised through an authority that is not operating. In payments, Instruction No. 39 imposes complaint-handling and redress duties on banks and microfinance institutions, but no comprehensive law covers all payment service providers, leaving mobile money operators outside the regime (2025).

Collection continues regardless. Kinshasa has deployed drone surveillance alongside a citizen-reporting app operated through a private company (January 2026), and the interior minister justifies population identification on national-security grounds — migration control, counter-terrorism and an "impératif régalien" (February 2026). Digital freedom is nonetheless one of the country's better rights measures, at 42.2 out of 100 and up 5.9 points over 2014-2023.

Regional collaboration

DR Congo belongs to four regional economic communities — COMESA, the East African Community, ECCAS and SADC — but scores 26.0 out of 100 on regional integration, 45th of 54 African states and down 4.9 points over 2014-2023.

Physical reach is the part that has moved. Eastern Congo was tied into the East African submarine corridor when a terrestrial route from Goma to Mombasa was lit in February 2026, giving Goma a land path to the Kenyan coast.

Institutional reach has not. Congolese digital identity is not recognised across borders: the country sits nominally inside a SADC federated eKYC framework announced in August 2025, which has been piloted only between South Africa and Lesotho. Cross-border payments into the country run through mobile money remittance corridors rather than a regional instant scheme.

Engagement with regional bodies is at the level of attendance and reporting. Outcomes from the African Telecommunications Union plenipotentiary summit held at Abuja on 20-25 July 2026 were put before the Council of Ministers the following month, and ARPTC hosted the FRATEL regulators' seminar in Kinshasa in May 2026.

Standards

Standards reach Congolese public systems one at a time, carried in by the vendor or the sector rather than mandated from a published national frame. Government systems sit in silos with no adopted interoperability framework (2023); there is no government cloud platform and no policy governing where government data may be hosted (2025), and no open-source software policy for government systems. The lever most states use to impose technical standards is missing too: DR Congo has no electronic government procurement system, and none of the associated functions, including any use of procurement to enforce standards (2025).

Where standards do bind, they arrived with a specific build. The biometric passport system conforms to the ICAO ISO/IEC 39794 standard (June 2025); Kinshasa's OADC Texaf facility holds ISO 27001 and ISO 22301 certification with PCI DSS compliance, allowing card-payment workloads to be hosted in-country (February 2025); and the facture normalisée invoicing format has been mandatory for VAT-liable firms since 1 December 2025. Accessibility is the clearest case of the gap: there is no legal definition of ICT accessibility and no reasonable-accommodation requirement (2025). Infrastructure sharing between operators is likewise being pursued by discussion at a regulators' seminar in May 2026 rather than by rule.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Consultation is improving while the ground it stands on gives way. Deliberative and participatory governance is DR Congo's second most improved governance indicator, up 18.7 points over 2014-2023 to 54.4 out of 100 and 31st of 54 African states; over the same decade civil society space fell 18.2 points to 22.8 and freedom of association and assembly fell 25.0 points to 12.5. Media conditions are middling and slipping: 46.7 out of 100 for media freedom and 52.9 for freedom of expression and belief, both down over the decade.

Participation in digital policymaking runs through invited workshops rather than open channels. The sector policy validation drew the digital economy, planning, presidency and prime minister's offices, the Fédération des Entreprises du Congo, ARPTC, ADN, the universal service fund, academics and civil society (July 2026). Outside the room there is little: no government e-participation platform and none of the five further participation mechanisms the index tracks, and no central citizen feedback or grievance-redress platform for public services (2025).

Access to records is among the country's weakest ground. Access to and disclosure of public records both sit in a sub-category, accountability and transparency, that is one of DR Congo's three worst (2023), and while a right to information law is recorded as in place, there is no route to ask for information that has not already been published (2025).

Civil society still intervenes on digital questions and is heard: the ACAJ publicly welcomed the licensing of Starlink as a corrective to what it called monopoly abuses by incumbent operators (May 2025). The limits of open debate show elsewhere: access to X and TikTok was restricted across the country for several days in February 2025, with the media regulator disclaiming knowledge of it and users routing around it with VPNs.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The largest digital figure on record for DR Congo has no financing behind it: the Ministry of Posts, Telecommunications and Digital Affairs and China's Genew Technologies have signed a memorandum of understanding for a Congo River fibre route of about 2,100 km, announced at US$1.5 billion with more than US$400 million needed for the first phase, the totals given by Genew's chief executive. No financier is named for any part of it and no contract has followed.

Most of what has been signed since is of the same kind. Visa and the Banque Centrale du Congo agreed in April 2026 to work on financial inclusion and payment modernisation, tied to the central bank's 2026-2030 strategic plan, and Mastercard and the Congolese fintech Flash agreed in July 2026 to issue prepaid cards. The education ministry and the FDSU signed a memorandum in April 2026 to connect schools into an interoperable education data ecosystem, ONIP and the National Commission for Refugees signed one in November 2024 on identifying refugees, and a November 2024 memorandum with Monaco's Monacosat opened a sovereign satellite programme. Each names the parties and the intent; none carries a financing instrument or a delivery date.

Of digital-sector commitments made between 2014 and 2026, the two largest headline figures both rest on instruments that commit no money: the Genew memorandum, and a 20-year exclusive concession for digital identity.

New investments

Agence Française de Développement is lending the government EUR 100 million (about US$109 million) over 2025-2031, co-financing the World Bank's US$400 million DRC Digital Transformation Project, 2024-2029, covering connectivity, digital government, digital identity and skills. That pair is the country's external digital financing, and the government's complaint in August 2026 was not their size but how slowly they disburse.

The other sovereign commitment is Chinese. China Eximbank and the government signed an RMB 1.05 billion (about US$170 million) concessional loan in the first quarter of 2020, at 2% over 20 years, for the Ministry of Finance ICT Modernization Project, with Huawei as contractor; it was undrawn as at August 2020; the ministry's Tier 3 data centre was inaugurated in November 2023.

Most of the rest goes to towers and fibre. Helios Towers signed an investment convention with the investment agency ANAPI in March 2026, covering more than US$100 million; the Emerging Africa Infrastructure Fund committed US$30 million of commercial debt to Eastcastle Infrastructure in 2023, with a further US$34 million from the IFC for the same platform at pipeline stage (July 2026). Finnfund lent Bandwidth and Cloud Services US$12 million in 2021, and the European Investment Bank added US$10 million of mezzanine finance in 2022 for a second fibre backbone phase in the east. Two MIGA guarantees, US$30 million on Helios Towers' towers (2014) and US$26 million on The Rise Fund II's equity in Airtel Money DRC (2021), are risk cover rather than capital. The single grant is Global Affairs Canada's CAD 8 million to UNICEF for birth registration, 2015-2018.

DR Congo has drawn 15 distinct digital-sector commitments between 2014 and 2026, with implementation windows running to 2031: six active, six closed, two pipeline, one approved but not disbursing. Setting aside an unsigned US$1.5 billion memorandum and counting the two China Eximbank records once, signed or approved commitments come to roughly US$1.05 billion, of which US$56 million is risk cover rather than capital. Connectivity accounts for nine of them, but with that memorandum set aside its contracted total falls behind digital identity and civil registration. Most of it is debt.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Rutshuru and Masisi in North Kivu went close to a month with no mobile network, from 19 January to 17 February 2026, residents falling back on neighbouring countries' networks while mobile money stopped. Days later, shelling in the AFC/M23 war took down the masts of all three operators at Rubaya, the principal coltan mining hub, for 24 hours. Damage is not the only failure mode: at Walikale-centre in March 2025 every network stopped because generator fuel could not reach tower sites in AFC/M23-held territory.

At least four network failures or restrictions were recorded between February 2025 and February 2026, from a 24-hour outage to a blackout of nearly a month, mobile money failing first in each of the eastern cases.

The east also gained a land route to the sea that month: Paratus lit its Goma-to-Mombasa fibre in February 2026. Nationally the network reaches far more people than use it — 3G covers 68% of the population and 4G 57% (2026), against about 19.7% of individuals using the internet in 2024 and fixed broadband access under 0.02% in 2023 on the regulator's own figures. Internet and Computers is one of the few Congolese governance measures moving backwards, down 9.6 points over 2014-2023 to 10.1 out of 100 (2023).

The state fibre programme had laid 7,000 km of backbone by August 2026 against a target above 18,500 km, with 145 territoires to connect by 2030. The universal service fund, unfunded for years after its 2020 creation, signed its first subsidy conventions on 8 August 2026 with Orange, Vodacom, Africell and Airtel, covering 40 rural and peri-urban localities and roughly 258,000 people. The largest announced build is a memorandum with China's Genew Technologies for about 2,100 km of fibre along the Congo River.

Satellite has gone from illegal to licensed to sold as a mobile service. ARPTC granted Starlink an internet service provider licence in May 2025, reversing its own March 2024 position that its terminals were illegal; it is resold into the interior, from an office opened at Kindu in April 2026; and in August 2026 Airtel and Starlink commercially launched satellite-to-mobile service in DR Congo, which the two companies call the first commercial deployment of Starlink Mobile in Africa — a compatible handset and a clear view of the sky, no additional equipment, and a free 30-day trial on registration, with no standing tariff or coverage map published. The state incumbent SCPT, meanwhile, could pay salaries only every four months, improved to roughly every two (June 2026).

Data Storage

DR Congo has no government cloud platform, no policy governing where government data may be hosted, and nothing published about its hosting arrangements (2025).

Commercial capacity, by contrast, is real and recent. Raxio's DRC1 in Kinshasa — 400 racks, 1.5 MW and Uptime Institute Tier III certification, inaugurated in August 2024 and operational — was built at a cost of $30 million as a carrier-neutral colocation facility. The OADC Texaf facility in the same city holds ISO 27001 and ISO 22301 certification together with PCI DSS compliance (February 2025), which allows card-payment workloads to be hosted in the country rather than abroad.

No hyperscale cloud region serves the country from within it, so anything wanting one is served from a distant region. Domestic traffic at least need not leave: the first distributed internet exchange point, ACIX, lets Congolese networks exchange traffic locally rather than routing it abroad (May 2026).

Where data may go is written but not yet enforceable. The Digital Code permits transfer abroad only where the receiving jurisdiction or organisation offers protection equal to or better than DR Congo's, and its implementing decrees have not been issued.

Energy

Electricity in DR Congo is an urban good: about 41% of urban residents had access against roughly 1% of rural residents (2024), and 22.1% of the population overall in 2023. Only around 7% of rural schools have power (2024), which rules out digital record-keeping at the point of service before any question of software arises.

For firms the binding problem is reliability as much as reach: 77.4% report electrical outages, averaging 11.6 a month, against 10.1 for low-income countries as a group (2024). Access to Energy is among the country's ten worst-scoring governance indicators, at 10.8 out of 100 and 48th of 54 African states (2023), and infrastructure as a whole is its second worst-scoring governance sub-category, 22.3 out of 100 and 48th of 54, though rising slowly (2023).

Generation is overwhelmingly hydroelectric, a national endowment that has not translated into supply. Residential tariffs have been fixed by ministerial decree since 2009, and off-grid electrification rests on a basic policy built on a 2014 electricity law, with limited implementation (2024).

Operators therefore build their own power rather than wait for a grid. Orange and Vodacom announced a joint rural network venture in January 2025 to build solar-powered 2G and 4G base stations. Where that supply chain breaks the network goes with it, as it did at Walikale-centre in March 2025, where the towers fell silent for want of generator fuel rather than from combat damage. Power is also named in the trade record as a continuing drag on internet use even where coverage has improved (May 2026).

Technical Capacity

The state's own technical work is done by borrowing from the regulator it supervises: ARPTC served as the technical arm of the government's digital maturity diagnostic in July 2026, collecting the data from public institutions and supervising the experts for the digital economy ministry. How thinly that capability is institutionalised showed when the 2023 dissolution of the social fund delivery agency FSRDC temporarily cut around 350,000 beneficiaries off from cash transfers — it sat in an agency, and went when the agency went.

The administrative trend is nonetheless upward. Effective Administration is among the country's ten most improved governance indicators, up 12.2 points over 2014-2023 to 41.2 out of 100 and 38th of 54 African states, and the statistical system's capacity rose 5.4 points over the same period to 35.4, 40th of 54. DR Congo scored about 0.3 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2022. Some of the missing capability is unglamorous and foundational: there is no national address register and no postal code system, so addressing remains informal.

Of the seven government systems whose software type is recorded, four — tax, human resources, payroll and social insurance — run custom software, and three — financial management, customs and debt management — run commercial off-the-shelf products.

Custom does not mean Congolese. The identity estate is run by foreign vendors on long contracts rather than maintained in country. The domestic pipeline exists: Congolese universities run computer science and ICT degrees, including a department at the University of Kinshasa Polytechnic established in 2005.

Cybersecurity

In July 2026 the digital economy minister called for a visible chain of responsibility in cybersecurity — who inspires, executes, regulates, controls and receives incident notifications, across the Conseil national de cybersécurité, the data protection authority, the central bank, the telecoms regulator ARPTC and the national cybersecurity agency — and stated explicitly that it must be done without creating new institutions. The bodies themselves come from the 2023 Digital Code, the framework law for digital identity, e-government, cybersecurity and data protection, which created the national cybersecurity agency alongside the electronic certification authority and the digital market regulator; several of its implementing decrees remain outstanding.

What the minister set out alongside the chain of responsibility is foundational rather than operational: critical infrastructure mapping, a minimum security baseline, a national architecture reference framework, reference data registries and a single digital identity. The sector policy validated in August 2026 carries cybersecurity as one of six axes to a 2030 horizon.

Measured from outside, the country sits in the ITU's lowest cybersecurity tier and outside the group of African states the ITU names as models (2024). The obligations that exist run ahead of the machinery to enforce them: the Digital Code requires a controller or data protection officer to notify a personal data breach without delay, to an authority that is not yet operating.

Certified security capability exists commercially before it exists in the state, in the Kinshasa data centre holding ISO 27001 and ISO 22301 with PCI DSS compliance (February 2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

The one exchange point that came into service in DR Congo carries internet traffic rather than government data: ACIX, the country's first distributed internet exchange point, built by DE-CIX with Internet pour Tous and United SA, lets domestic traffic be exchanged inside the country instead of being routed abroad (May 2026).

Between government systems there is no equivalent layer. The World Bank identified the absence of any cross-government data-exchange or interoperability platform as an outstanding reform priority, with the population register connected to no such system (2021), and two years later government systems still sat in silos with no comprehensive cross-government data-sharing law and no adopted e-government interoperability framework.

System by system it is consistent. The customs single window, the SYDONIA World customs platform and the online tax portal run standalone with no integration between them (2023); the non-tax revenue platform LOGIRAD and the new tax management software are connected to no cross-government exchange (2024); the digital civil servant registry has neither its planned link to the payroll system nor any link to the population identity office (2025); the health information system and the health human resources system function as separate silos; and farmer registries, land records, input-voucher and extension data sit outside any government data-exchange platform.

Data therefore moves in bulk handovers rather than across interfaces. The electoral commission's transfer of its biometric voter file to the identification office in February 2026 was the largest such movement, and it was a delivery of a file between two agencies. The feed that was meant to replace it — automatic updating of the population file from civil-status records — is not operating, and civil registers remain largely manual and outside any central file (April 2026).

The intent is on the record twice: the digital economy ministry named reference data registries and a single digital identity as common bases to be built in July 2026, and a bill tabled in June 2026 would mandate interoperability across the civil registry, migration and health databases, though it is not law.

Digital Identity and CRVS

DR Congo's national digital identity platform, RDC-PASS, was launched on 13 June 2026 in a state ceremony under President Félix Tshisekedi, with citizen enrolment only beginning at launch, under a twenty-year partnership making Singapore-listed Trident Digital Tech the country's exclusive electronic know-your-customer provider. The Ministry of Planning values the programme at US$97.1 million, with no published financing plan (January 2026), and no independent security review or privacy impact assessment has been published, the partnership's contract terms remaining undisclosed.

That concession replaced an earlier one. The US$1.2 billion biometric identity contract with IDEMIA, held through the intermediary Afritech, was cancelled on 12 August 2024 after the Inspectorate General of Finance flagged cost irregularities and illegal financing arrangements. Re-tendering followed, with phased deployment under way by August 2025, a move in November 2025 to relaunch identity card issuance through ONIP, and an announced start of national identification operations in May 2026. A physical-card track is being pursued in parallel with the foreign e-KYC concession, through a prospective arrangement with Ghana's Margins ID Group, producer of the Ghana Card.

Almost nothing yet rests on any of it. No national identity cards were issued between the 1990s and a 2022 pilot of roughly 700 cards in Kinshasa, the voter's card has served as the de facto national identity document since the 1980s and the biometric card was still undelivered in mid-2026, and the World Bank places the country among the lowest-access economies in the region, with under 70% of adults holding any form of identification (2024). The new platform binds fingerprint and facial biometrics to citizen records, with biometric SIM-card registration among its primary use cases.

Civil registration underneath it is paper. It runs through around 979 local civil-status offices with no single nationwide repository, using four-copy carbon registers with no device used in the act of registration; birth registration covered around 40% of children under five in 2018, and digitisation is confined to pilots in individual Kinshasa communes (2025).

Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank has set a hard stop for cash dollars: from 9 April 2027 no foreign-currency cash transaction of any amount will be permitted in DR Congo, and foreign currency may be used only scripturally (April 2026). It puts [financial access at 58% against bank-account penetration of 25–30%](https://actualite.cd/2026/05/04/inclusion-financiere-en-rdc-58-dacces-contre-25-30-de-bancarisation-la-bcc-parie-sur-la.

Mobile money, not the banking system, is the rail. There were 24.45 million 90-day active mobile money accounts as of June 2024, a penetration rate of 45%, and person-to-person transfer runs over M-Pesa, Orange Money, Airtel Money and Afrimoney. Use is thinner than accounts: 22% of individuals reported making or receiving a digital payment in the previous year (2024).

The public rails are old and partly idle. The Automated Transfer System providing real-time gross settlement and clearing was deployed in September 2017, and the national retail card switch became operational in December 2020 with 11 banks connected but only 5 live (2021). A national interbank platform joining banks and mobile money providers remained a target rather than a live system (March 2026).

Interoperability is arriving privately instead. Visa Pay launched on 4 September 2025, carrying near-real-time account-to-account transfers across participating banks and mobile networks in both Congolese francs and US dollars; Ecobank began automating electronic-money creation for super-agents with Airtel in November 2025 and added Orange Money in January 2026; Mastercard and the Congolese fintech Flash agreed in July 2026 to issue prepaid cards. Some of it runs in the currency the state is retiring: FirstBank extended dollar digital banking by USSD in October 2025, and stablecoin settlement now sits behind consumer wallet transactions rather than being offered as a consumer product (July 2026).

Government-to-person payment shows the gaps. Rawbank and Equity BCDC have paid teachers' wages through digital channels in eastern DR Congo since March 2025, and rural civil-service pay is to run through CADECO, which holds around 40 sites where no other bank is present but whose core banking replacement and ATMs were still in test rather than production on 25 July 2026; its director general said the day before that it was premature to fix a launch date, with the state contract unsigned.

Registries

DR Congo acquired a second population register before the first one worked: a decree of 4 December 2025 created the Registre Social Unique, centralising biographic, biometric and programme data on social-protection beneficiaries, with provisions for interoperability, sitting alongside the ONIP civil identity register.

The foundational register remains a design. A 2022 decree established the General Population File, holding biographic and biometric data under ONIP, to be updated automatically from civil-status records and to serve as the basis for the national identification number and card; neither the civil-registration feed nor card issuance from it is operating.

Land is the longest-running failure. There is no operational nationwide digital land register: a 2022 contract with Luxembourg's eProseed collapsed, the government turned to Dubai-based Oxinus in early 2025 to relaunch the e-Foncier programme, and a blockchain land-title pilot began in June 2025. A ministerial order of 2016 had already directed digitisation of the cadastre onto a national database server, unconnected to other registries, and the new land law mandates it again.

Business registration is the one register with a working digital front. The one-stop window has run digital business registration since 2013, with online name verification and case tracking, coordinating company registration with issuance of tax, social security and vocational training numbers in a single process. Full company creation still runs through the revenue directorate, a collecting bank, the notariat, folios and verification steps outside that digital front door, with extension of branches to the provinces requested rather than delivered (July 2026).

Elsewhere the registers are real but unjoined. The biometric driving licence system run by KODINET holds a centralised database linking licences, vehicles and traffic offences, with checks enforced in all zones served by issuing centres (November 2025); the ENCORE biometric registry of civil servants has issued more than 118,000 cards across all 26 provinces (July 2025). There is no national address register and no postal code system at all, leaving these files without a common way to locate the person or firm they describe. In 2023 the dissolution of the social fund delivery agency cut around 350,000 beneficiaries off from cash transfers.

Sectoral management information systems

DR Congo's flagship health system reaches every province and is fed by paper: DHIS2 has been operational since 2014 across all 26 provinces, while rural clinics complete paper registers and weekly epidemiological forms that are carried or relayed verbally to the health zone office for entry into the national platform (2024).

Seven of the ten core back-office government systems the GovTech Maturity Index tracks are in use in the country — financial management, tax, customs, human resources, payroll, social insurance and debt management — while three are absent: the treasury single account, electronic procurement, and public investment management (2025). Of the seven systems whose software type is recorded, four run custom-built software and three run commercial off-the-shelf products.

Revenue administration is the most built-out and the least connected. The customs single window, SYDONIA World and the online tax portal are all operational but run standalone (2023); LOGIRAD has linked six revenue-collecting agencies across most provinces since 2022, and integrated tax management software has been rolling out at the tax authority from 2024, neither connected to a cross-government exchange. Behind them there is no treasury single account, and none of the four supporting treasury measures are in place, though the financial management system does reach local government (2025).

Payroll is the fiscal reason for much of it. The ENCORE project built the first digital civil servant registry, with integration to the SIGRH-Paie payroll planned but not made and no link to the population identity office (2025), against a public wage bill that takes a large share of state spending.

Education and justice run their own islands. The education management information system is operational for school statistics, but a 2024 evaluation found its databases unharmonised and donor-dependent, and ministry digitisation takes the form of periodic externally run school censuses rather than day-to-day capture by school staff. A decree of March 2025 established SIGAJ, a case-management system for the commercial courts, now in 86 jurisdictions across 14 cities, and the higher-education portal ESURSI went live on 30 March 2026 carrying student identity, transcripts and diploma equivalences.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A Congolese citizen has no single front door to the state: the country has no national government service portal, and none of the six portal capabilities the index tracks — including any route to registering a company online — are in place (2025).

Citizen-facing digital government is sectoral rather than unified: three of the seven public-facing channels the index tracks exist — the tax, social protection and jobs portals — while the national service portal, the open data portal, the e-participation platform and the citizen feedback platform do not (2025).

Tax is where the state has reached the taxpayer. Electronic invoicing under the facture normalisée regime has been mandatory for all VAT and ICG-liable firms since 1 December 2025, having been operationalised on 1 August 2025, with more than 4,000 free electronic invoicing units distributed to small businesses; on 6 August 2026 the finance minister closed the taxpayer support clinics and ordered targeted sanctions against non-compliant taxpayers and against tax officials who allow undocumented VAT deductions, calling the level of collection reached very largely below potential. Taxpayers can register, file and pay online, with monthly VAT declaration mandatory through the teledeclaration platform.

Businesses have a comparable channel: the one-stop registration window issues entreprenant activity attestations by mobile app in under 48 hours, and the Ministry of National Economy launched an E-Contrôle platform in June 2026 that authenticates inspection documents against forgery during economic controls.

The most-used citizen transaction carries a notable condition. The biometric passport launched in June 2025 requires online registration and mandatory approval by the national intelligence agency before biometric capture, with capture centres still being installed across provinces and no integration with immigration or border-control data; the price was cut sharply under the new supplier.

What the state does not offer is as telling. There is no electronic government procurement system, and none of its four associated functions (2025), and no e-participation platform or central citizen feedback channel. Where it reaches daily life, it often runs through private operators: Kinshasa has deployed drone surveillance alongside a citizen-reporting app, KIN ALERTE, run through a private company (January 2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Sub-national government sits largely outside the digital state. A study of 24 municipalities in Kinshasa found legacy systems unable to integrate with anything else, with digital services concentrated in the capital across the country's 26 provinces (2023) — and Kinshasa is the tier that has gone furthest, having since paired drone surveillance with a citizen-reporting app operated through a private company (January 2026).

What exists below the centre mostly reaches down from it. The civil service biometric registry has issued cards in every province (July 2025), the financial management system is recorded as operating at local as well as central government level (2025) even though no treasury single account exists to consolidate what it manages, and an EU-funded human resources system now handles police staffing at provincial commands including Tshikapa, Bunia and Mbandaka, while case recording stays on paper (2025). Provincial and territorial offices run little of their own: digitisation of civil registration is confined to pilot communes in Kinshasa (2025), and extension of the one-stop company registration window to the provinces has been requested rather than delivered (July 2026).

Rural digital data capture

Almost all of the digital data capture that happens outside Kinshasa is donor-built and pilot-scale. Nurses in part of Haut-Katanga have been entering disease surveillance returns on Android tablets connected to DHIS2 since October 2022; a case-management system has been piloted for facility-level entry in one health zone in Kwango (2025); and a mobile application that synchronises to DHIS2 carries community health workers' reporting (2024). Around those programmes the rural clinic is still paper at the point of care, its registers and weekly forms carried or relayed to the health zone office and typed into the national platform there (2024).

The pattern holds beyond health. Rural civil registry offices record births, deaths and marriages entirely on paper, with no device used in the registration act itself (2025), and rural police stations write their case files up on paper as well (2025). Where the state has reached the provinces digitally it has largely done so by travelling: mobile registration caravans took business creation services to Bunia, Kananga and Mbuji-Mayi in 2025. The most developed field capture is humanitarian rather than governmental — the World Food Programme's biometric card payments routing aid through local markets in Masisi (April 2026), built after Kinshasa closed banks in AFC/M23-held areas. School data is gathered in periodic externally run exercises by enumerators with tablets, not by school staff day to day, and almost no rural school has the electricity that routine record-keeping would need (2024).

The state's own moves are recent and unfinished. The universal service fund launched its first pilot connectivity sites at Nkamba in Kongo Central on 30 May 2026, the first state-financed rural telecommunications build, under a ten-year infrastructure-sharing strategy aimed at the rural population (2026), and the plan to pay rural civil servants through CADECO rests on a core banking system still in test rather than production (July 2026). Rural conditions have meanwhile been improving in the governance assessments: Rural Economy Support rose 12.5 points over 2014-2023 to 55.8 out of 100 and Rural Representation and Participation 9.9 points to 31.0, both among DR Congo's ten most improved indicators (2023).

Technology

AI

DR Congo's national artificial intelligence strategy, SNIA-RDC, passed technical validation at a workshop held from 23 to 27 July 2026 and then stopped there: it has not been officially adopted and no adoption date has been established, leaving the country without an AI strategy in force (July 2026).

The reason the strategy matters more than most is what officials said alongside it. Several Congolese bodies already act across digital, research, data, cybersecurity and regulation, but their roles are "not yet sufficiently articulated in a common steering architecture" (July 2026) — an admission on the record that AI governance in DR Congo has no single coordinating structure. The draft is aligned to the national development plan PNSD 2024-2028 and sets a 2030 horizon, and rests on four pillars: governance, ethics, trust and regulation; data, digital and energy infrastructure; human capital, research and innovation; and industrialisation and value creation.

What government has set out so far is a condition on use rather than a rule of law: the digital economy minister has stated that no AI platform should be deployed in the state without data quality, auditability and human supervision (July 2026).

Deployment is where the answer thins out. The World Bank's govtech assessment records no use of artificial intelligence in citizen-facing government channels (2025), and the activity on the record sits at workshop level: a Kinshasa workshop on 23 July 2026 recommended responsible use of artificial intelligence in the digital economy, with no binding instrument attached to the recommendation, following a UNESCO workshop in Kinshasa in July 2025 on integrating ICT and artificial intelligence into public services. The sector policy moving in parallel carries digital trust, data governance, cybersecurity and responsible AI as one of its strategic orientations and reached government validation on 4 August 2026, a third validation gate inside a fortnight.

ICT Industry

Every large technology build in DR Congo carries a foreign name on it. The national digital identity platform runs on a stack supplied by the vendor Trident, the carrier-neutral colocation data centre in Kinshasa was built by Raxio, and the towers carrying mobile coverage are run by the international operator Helios Towers (2026).

The regulators have started to push against that. The subcontracting regulator ARSP and the telecoms regulator ARPTC agreed on 22 July 2026 to harmonise their reading of the legal texts, run joint inspection teams and enforce local-content subcontracting rules on large operators, following a sector reset convened through états généraux of posts and telecommunications in October 2025. The domestic sector is not absent, and it is deepest in payments: MultiPay, launched in 2015 on an Interswitch backend, was the country's first locally operated interbank payment service.

The ground the sector runs on is improving slowly from a low base. Business and competition regulation scored 42.5 out of 100 in 2023, up 9.0 points over the decade, and still ranked 42nd of 54 African states. Firm formation remains an over-the-counter transaction: there is no route to registering a company online (2025). The AI strategy's own economic case for a domestic sector rests on the minerals rather than the software — it argues that the country's cobalt and coltan endowments should be converted into an advantage through the AI economy (July 2026), without setting out the mechanism.

Innovation ecosystem

DR Congo's startup funding record is one company deep. The ecosystem raised US$38 million in 2022 on Partech data, but 98% of it went to a single Web3 company, Jambo, and the largest fintech round since was Tuma's US$500,000 in 2023.

The support layer is thicker than the money going through it. A directory published in April 2026 with the International Trade Centre and FCDO maps at least ten active entrepreneur-support and tech hubs, among them Silikin Village, Ingenious City, LUBA Hub, Kobo Hub and the Centre d'innovation de Lubumbashi, and government financing for technology firms, support for small enterprises and public-private arrangements for delivering government services online are recorded as in place (2025). The sector policy validated in August 2026 carries innovation and start-ups as one of its six axes to a 2030 horizon.

Whether any of that produces measurable output is not something the country currently tests itself on: DR Congo is not among the 133 economies ranked in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024, unlike comparable African states such as Cameroon and Angola. Absorption of new technology happens at product level — a palm-vein biometric payment terminal launched in April 2026 — more readily than through government, which has no open-source software policy governing its systems (2025).

Capacity

Literacy

The strongest score DR Congo holds across all 96 indicators of the Ibrahim Index is its teachers: Human Resources in Education stands at 91.2 out of 100 (2023), 15th of 54 African states, having slipped 2.9 points since 2014. What those teachers deliver scores nothing like as well. Education Enrolment reached 46.7 (2023), a gain of 8.3 points over the decade and the country's 20th-best rank, while Education Quality sits at 24.2 in 44th place, down 4.4 points, and Equality in Education at 29.1 in 49th. So more children are in school, the teaching workforce is among the continent's better-supplied, and what is learned there ranks near the bottom. The index carries no Education Completion score for the country at all, leaving no measure of whether pupils finish the schooling they start.

The digital layer over this is very recent. The government adopted a national ICT-for-education and training policy on 12 June 2026, aimed at making scattered education technology initiatives work together, and the country has joined the UNESCO and UNICEF Gateways to Public Digital Learning initiative (March 2026). The schools data those efforts would rest on is a standalone silo, its databases unharmonised and its capacity donor-dependent (2024).

Training and skills

Digital skills training in DR Congo runs as discrete events rather than a standing programme. UNESCO ran a workshop in Kinshasa in July 2025 on integrating ICT and artificial intelligence into public services, the capacity-building thread behind the government's govtech push, and in February 2025 Internet Society members and young people in Kinshasa were taken through the universal service fund's case for connecting peri-urban and rural areas. Sustained instruction at degree level runs through the universities, the University of Kinshasa's Polytechnic faculty among them.

The stated ambition is much larger than any of that. The national artificial intelligence strategy makes human capital, research and innovation one of its four pillars — a commitment on paper, with no training programme yet attached to it.

What has been built instead sits either side of instruction rather than inside it. Entrepreneur-support and technology hubs operate in Kinshasa and Lubumbashi (April 2026), and the national employment office has launched a digital database mapping skills against employers' needs (July 2026) — matching people to jobs, not equipping them for those jobs. The stock of technical staff available to the administration is a separate matter.

Research institutions

The ESURSI higher-education portal went live on 30 March 2026 with World Bank and AFD backing, carrying student identity, transcripts and diploma equivalences, and opening the country's first national digital library — an access route to knowledge before it is a means of producing any. Domestic computing research has a home at the University of Kinshasa's Polytechnic faculty, whose computer engineering department runs artificial intelligence, software and network laboratories. The national artificial intelligence strategy rests on four pillars: governance, ethics, trust and regulation; data, digital and energy infrastructure; human capital, research and innovation; and industrialisation and value creation.

Inclusion

Access to services

Equal Access to Public Services is one of DR Congo's four most improved governance indicators, up 17.7 points over the decade to 2023 to 31.1 out of 100 and 34th of 54 African states — movement from a base so low that it still sits under a third of the scale.

Obtaining something from the state online means knowing which sector to approach: there is no national government service portal and no route to registering a company online, and no e-participation platform through which a citizen could ask anything of government. Nor is any of it built for disabled users. A general disability rights law exists, but there is no legal definition of ICT accessibility, no reasonable-accommodation requirement, no universal service obligation extending to persons with disabilities and no established route for disabled people's organisations into ICT policymaking (2025).

The incomplete identity register bites less at the clinic, where documents are accepted rather than required for health care and schooling. It bites hardest on the displaced: only a small minority of registered refugees hold a refugee identity card, though the identification agency has begun adding refugee and stateless indicators to its questionnaire and signed an identification agreement with the refugee commission in November 2024.

In the east, services stop when the network does. When mobile networks in Rutshuru and Masisi went down for close to a month in early 2026, mobile money went with them. What runs there is improvised: banks have paid teachers through digital channels since March 2025 where branches cannot operate, and the World Food Programme routes aid through a biometric card system in Masisi after banks in AFC/M23-held areas were closed, on a programme that delivered well short of its 2025 plan. Elsewhere the state travels to people, through mobile registration caravans that formalised businesses in Bunia, Kananga and Mbuji-Mayi (2025) and through the one bank with branches in some 40 places where no other operates.

Anything delivered online still meets a hard ceiling: roughly 65 million mobile connections sit against internet penetration of 30.5%, about 35 million users (2026).

Digital divides

Around 79 million people in DR Congo were offline in 2025, some 40 million of them living inside mobile coverage they do not use: the largest excluded group in the country is not the group the networks have failed to reach.

The uncovered remainder is smaller but absolute. Nearly 3,000 localities, home to around 4.3 million people, had no mobile signal of any kind (September 2025), against national coverage of 77% for 2G, 68% for 3G and 57% for 4G. Where there is a signal it is far thicker in the towns: internet penetration ran at about 38% in urban areas against roughly 25% in rural ones (2025), and the same line divides household electrification and power at rural schools, both of which are close to absent outside the cities.

Underneath the coverage gap sits a device gap. Smartphones account for only about 40% of mobile connections, and an entry-level handset costs a median of around $305 (2026), which is what keeps tens of millions of covered people on voice and text. The divide also runs by sex: women are substantially less likely than men to own a phone or to use mobile internet (2024).

None of this is closing. Equal Socioeconomic Opportunity scored 13.0 out of 100 in 2023, 51st of 54 African states and 6.4 points lower than a decade earlier, and the same profile has internet and computer access among the few infrastructure measures moving backwards in a country of 102.3 million people with GDP per capita of USD 649, 45th of 54 (2023). In June 2025 the government was directed to redouble its efforts to close the digital divide; the first money behind that instruction reached operators in August 2026.

Data

National statistics

DR Congo had held no population census, no agricultural census and no business census in the twenty years to 2023, and the survey programme standing in for them is uneven: three or more labour force surveys in the decade to 2023, against a single agricultural survey, a single business survey and two rounds each of household and health surveys.

The weakness sits at the point of production. On the same 2023 assessment the weakest pillars are data sources and data infrastructure, both in the 20-49% band, while data services and data products score 50-69% and data use 70-89% — numbers get used more readily than they get made.

That ordering follows from how the administrative record is kept. Civil registration runs on paper through local civil-status offices with no single nationwide repository (2026); rural clinics fill in paper registers and weekly epidemiological forms that are carried or relayed to the health zone office before anything reaches the national DHIS2 platform (2024); and school records travel to provincial and central offices as paper registers and printed questionnaires before they become national education statistics (2024). Education has an operational management information system in SIGE, but a 2024 evaluation found its databases unharmonised and the capacity behind them fragmented and donor-dependent.

The trend is upward and slow: the Capacity of the Statistical System score reached 35.4 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54 African states, after gaining 5.4 points over the preceding decade. The clearest recent move is in dissemination rather than collection — in June 2025 the country implemented the IMF's enhanced General Data Dissemination System and launched a National Summary Data Page bringing macroeconomic series from several statistical agencies into one portal.

Where the state does not produce, others record the hole. The Ibrahim Index carries no data for DR Congo on a block of indicators covering, among others, whether pupils complete the schooling they enrol in and how easy the public finds it to obtain an identity document, and the country is not ranked at all in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024.

Open data

Public access to the state's records is not only poor but getting worse: access to public records scored 22.1 out of 100 in 2023, 36th of 54 African states and down 13.4 points over the preceding decade, with disclosure of public records at 22.9 and 40th, both sitting inside an Accountability and Transparency sub-category that is one of the country's three weakest.

There is no government open data portal (2025) — no catalogue, no update cycle and no maintenance regime, because there is nothing to describe.

What does get published scores badly on coverage and openness together. DR Congo's strongest 2024 Open Data Inventory results are 5.5 out of 10 for price statistics and 5 for government finance, natural resources, health facilities and population, with no category reaching six; gender statistics and poverty statistics are the weakest published categories, at 2.5 each.

Across the 23 categories assessed in 2024, the average openness and coverage score is 3.3 out of 10, and nothing rises above 5.5.

The institutional side is equally thin. Nothing about how government systems handle data is published, and the body responsible for data governance sits inside another institution rather than standing on its own (2025), while neither the data protection regime nor the authority meant to oversee it publishes anything about its own work (2025). A right-to-information law is on the statute book and rated as effective (2025), a question whose legislative history belongs elsewhere in this report; its practical reach is bounded by how little is published in the first place. The pattern repeats in the payment system, where no regular disclosure of transaction volumes or uptime for the RTGS, clearing house or card switch exists and the central bank's annual reports are the only public accounting (2025).

Use of satellite data

No national arrangement for acquiring, holding or using Earth observation data was in place as at August 2026, and the country's only satellite undertaking is a memorandum of understanding signed with Monaco's Monacosat in November 2024 for a sovereign satellite programme (August 2025).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The largest American position in Congolese connectivity was created by the regulator reversing itself: ARPTC granted Starlink a full internet service provider licence in May 2025, having ruled in March 2024 that the company held no title in the country and that its terminals were illegal. The reversal was treated domestically as a competition remedy rather than a foreign entry — the ACAJ welcomed the licensing as a corrective to monopoly abuses by the incumbent operators. What the licence has since bought is a position in state emergency response as well as the retail market: Starlink delivered 150 satellite connection kits for the Ebola response in Ituri province in June 2026, putting a single foreign operator's terminals inside an outbreak's reporting chain.

In payments the American card networks are attaching themselves to the state and to the largest domestic wallet rather than building their own. Visa signed an agreement with the Banque Centrale du Congo in April 2026 tied to the central bank's own 2026–2030 strategic plan, which places a US network inside the modernisation programme of the monetary authority. Mastercard agreed in July 2026 to issue prepaid cards with the Congolese fintech Flash, which reports 3 million customers and 4,000 agents, opening card-to-wallet rails outside the Visa arrangements. Settlement is moving the same way: Visa has confirmed a live Congolese case in which wallet top-ups are settled in stablecoins in the background, bypassing correspondent banking altogether.

The other American presence is a claim rather than an asset. A US fintech is suing the DRC in US federal court over a collapsed state banking-modernisation project, with Kinshasa maintaining that the papers amount only to a non-binding memorandum — a dispute about whether the government's signature on a digitisation deal binds it at all, being settled in a foreign court.

China activities

China's largest presence in the Congolese digital sector is not yet contracted. The Ministry of Posts, Telecommunications and Digital Affairs and Genew Technologies have signed a memorandum for a fibre route of about 2,100 km, 1,700 km of it running along the Congo River from Muanda to Kisangani with nearly 400 km of terrestrial links — a route that would follow the country's central artery, in a market where backbone has otherwise been financed in short eastern segments. It remains a memorandum: no construction contract has been signed and no start date set.

What China does hold is a position inside the revenue machinery. China Eximbank and the government signed an RMB 1.05 billion concessional loan in the first quarter of 2020 — 20-year maturity, five-year grace, 2% interest, 0.25% commitment fee — for the Ministry of Finance ICT Modernization Project, covering the computer systems of the tax, customs and state revenue directorates with Huawei Technologies as implementing contractor. That is a single foreign vendor, on state-to-state credit, in the systems that assess and collect the government's own money. The visible output is a Tier 3 data centre at the Ministry of Finance, built under the same facility.

Across digital-sector commitments made between 2014 and 2026, the Genew memorandum is the largest single figure and the Ministry of Finance loan the third largest, but the memorandum is unsigned and the largest contracted and active commitment in the country remains the World Bank's US$400 million. China Eximbank is one of only three financiers appearing more than once in the record.

EU activities

Europe's position in DR Congo is inside the state's own systems, arriving as the junior partner in someone else's programme. Agence Française de Développement is lending the government EUR 100 million over 2025–2031 for the DRC Digital Transformation Project, co-financing the World Bank operation that covers digital infrastructure, digital government, digital identity, connectivity and skills — meaning French money sits behind the identity layer without French institutions holding it. The World Bank package is the senior half of that pair and the Finance chapter carries the figures.

The more durable European holding is a stake in one private backbone company. The European Investment Bank first lent to Bandwidth and Cloud Solutions in 2018 for the first phase of its fibre backbone, then returned in 2022 with US$10 million of mezzanine finance — EIB Global's first quasi-equity operation anywhere — for a second phase adding about 1,400 km of fibre along 1,280 km of railway and 139 km of road to reach nine towns in the underserved east. Finnfund lent the same group US$12 million in 2021 for its Congolese expansion, wholesaling capacity onward to ISPs, operators and government. European development finance is therefore an owner's stake in the wholesale layer the state itself buys from.

European money also builds registries directly. Belgium's Enabel funded MIKUBA, the national employment office's skills-and-vacancies database launched in July 2026, and an EU-funded police reform programme has put a human-resources system into the national police, running career and staffing management at provincial level while stopping short of case recording (2025).

The European Investment Bank is one of only three financiers appearing more than once in DR Congo's digital-sector record, and the French development agency's commitment is the fourth largest by value.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state, sovereign fund or Gulf-owned operator held an identified position in DR Congo's digital sector as at August 2026.

India activities

India held no identified position in DR Congo's digital infrastructure, payments or public-sector systems as at August 2026.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-08-25**
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/COD/COD-status.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/COD/COD-status-2026-08-25.pdf
LICENCE	CC BY 4.0

Figures are dated because most are time-varying: a figure carries the date it was true, not the date you are reading it. Where the base holds no reliable statement, the document says **Not held** rather than leaving a silence — those are counted, and listed at the end.

This is a dated edition and is not revised after publication. If a figure here has moved, the current edition will say so.